February 1990 that our peaceful neighbour had turned into a safe haven for anti-India elements. Though Singh had a very frosty relationship with the R&AW, he instructed us to create a well-defined mechanism to carry out our plans. There has been a lot of misinformation about the role that the agency played. It was said that we were disrupters, but in reality, we were supporting pro-democratic elements. The IB and R&AW both believed that we needed more assets and eavesdroppers on both sides of the border to maintain a grip on the events unfolding in the wake of the people's uprising.'

The Lucknow-based operational headquarters of the R&AW's Nepal unit buzzed with activity in the early 1990s. Many top Nepalese leaders had offered their services in building a strong movement for constitutional democracy. Since such operations need to be managed politically, every decision taken by the R&AW officers handling Nepal was conveyed to the top brass in Delhi. Arora said that every important conversation was monitored at the listening posts. These were shared with field agents for appropriate action including covert operations. In his words, 'It was a neat operation that successfully hunted down ISI elements and neutralised the forces obstructing democracy. These twin objectives could have only been achieved through clandestine activities. I cannot divulge the operational details, but we ran a spectacular spy mission with highly placed assets inside Nepal.'

A spy codenamed Ravi S. Sinha cultivated assets in the Nepalese Congress and the Communist Party of Nepal in support of Operation Mechi that had galvanised support for the people's movement. He was the driving force behind the move to end the monarchy in Nepal, which was helping forces inimical to India to use its land. Sinha said that he had held several rounds